



Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship

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June 4 2024

Dr. Sophie D'Amours, Rector
Université Laval
2325, rue de l'Université,
Québec (Québec) G1V 0A6

Re: Dr. Patrick Provost

Dear Dr. D'Amours,

I am writing you as President of the Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship (SAFS), an association of Canadian scholars committed to the principles of academic freedom and the merit principle. You can read more information about our organization at www.safs.ca.

We want to express our concerns regarding the recent firing of Professor Patrick Provost at the University of Laval. Professor Provost, according to multiple media reports, has been disciplined, suspended and more recently fired for his public criticisms around the use of mRNA COVID vaccines.

Such a turn of events is regrettable not only for what it has done to interfere with the academic freedom of Professor Provost but also because of its potential effect on the wider community. Academic institutions maintain public trust through their disinterested search for truth and their openness to scholarly critique. If however, it becomes apparent that the ultimate conclusions are preordained and that certain orthodoxies are not to be questioned, then the university may be rightfully seen by members of the public as bastions not of empirical investigations open to criticism but rather places of dogma and unquestionable truths. One would expect that academic

members of the university community, in pursuit of their duties, would have the right to think and argue otherwise regarding widely held positions. Others in the university community should, likewise, be able to publicly question such arguments and offer counterarguments in defending the currently held consensus.

We believe that by firing Professor Provost your university has sent a clear message to researchers to tread carefully when wading into certain debates. This message should concern not only those supportive of Provost's positions but also those who may wish to criticize a consensus position in that such individuals may fear, quite reasonably, that they may meet with censure if their findings diverge in any significant way from the established orthodoxy. The ultimate result is quite likely to be a chill on the expression of heterodox positions, particularly in science, and would impede the discovery of new understandings which might increase our knowledge about science and the world around us.

We respectfully request that you respond to our letter. With your permission, we will post your response along with this letter on our website.

Sincerely,

Robert G. Thomas
President, Society for Academic Freedom and Scholarship.

CC: Hon. Pascale Déry, MNA, Minister of Higher Education.
Marie-Hélène Parizeau, President of SPUL